The Good Friday Agreement

- sustainable peace or temporary solution?

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Introduction

Defining the leading question:

- Strengths and weaknesses of the agreement
- Could it have addressed the actual causes more instead of just forcing peace?

Particular focus and why?

- Good Friday Agreement
- Developments leading upto it

Background of the Troubles

Government of Ireland Act

- "Old English" displacing Irish in Ulster
- Division of the Isle of Ireland in Northern Ireland and Republic of Ireland

Systematic Discrimination of Catholics:

- protestants outnumbered Catholics → biased voting
- limited representation of Catholics

Key actors:

- British- and Irish government
- UUP
- civilians

Background of the Troubles

Civil rights movement

- NICRA organizes marches to protest against discrimination and “gerrymandering” → violent suppression of marchers by RUC
- Battle of Bogside
- arrival of British army

Key actors:

- NICRA
- RUC
- British army

Background of the Troubles

Emergence of the Provisional IRA (Provos) and loyalist paramilitaries

- British army ultimately viewed as enemy
  → Provisional IRA as defenders of the nationalist cause
- Armed Unionist organizations: UVF, UDA

Key actors:

- Irish Republican Army
- Unionist Paramilitaries

Background of the Troubles

Internment, "peace walls“, and „Bloody Sunday“

- "One man, one vote"
- Building of Peace Walls
- Bloody Sunday: British troops fired on catholic civil rights activists
  → highest level of recruitment in Provisional IRA

Key actors:

- Northern Ireland government

Background of the Troubles

First peace talks

- began 1973 with Sunningdale Agreement
- continued with the 1985 Anglo-Irish-Agreement
  ➔ Both failed

Key actors:

- Northern Irish parties
- British government
- Irish government

The Good Friday Agreement

- Peace Treaty signed by Brith and Irish gouvernments on April 10, 1998

The Good Friday Agreement

The Three Strands

- Strand 1: Northern Ireland Assembly
- Strand 2: North/South Ministerial Council
- Strand 3:
  - British-Irish Council
  - British-Irish Intergovernmental Conference

The Good Friday Agreement

Northern Ireland Assembly

- 108 Elected Members
  → self-designated Nationalist or Unionist

> A 108-member Assembly will be elected by PR(STV) from existing Westminster constituencies.

- major decisions require cooperation between Nationalist and Unionist

> ...key decisions are taken on a cross-community basis

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North/South Ministerial Council

- Ministers from Northern Ireland Executive and Irish Government → cooperation and decision-making on cross-border issues
- 6 formal areas of cooperation
- Plenary meetings twice a year
- *mutually interdependent with the Northern Ireland Assembly*

> The North/South Ministerial Council and the Northern Ireland Assembly are mutually inter-dependent, and that one cannot successfully function without the other.

The Good Friday Agreement

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The Good Friday Agreement

British-Irish Council

- membership: British & Irish Governments, devolved institutions in NI, Scotland, Wales, Isle of Man and Channel Islands
- meets at summit level twice per year

> A British-Irish Council (BIC) will be established [...] to promote the harmonious and mutually beneficial development of the totality of relationships among the peoples of these islands.

The Good Friday Agreement

The Three Strands

- Strand 1: Northern Ireland Assembly
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The Good Friday Agreement

British-Irish Intergovernmental Conference

- replaces institutions established under the 1985 Anglo-Irish Agreement
- co-chaired by Irish Minister for Foreign Affairs &
  UK Secretary of State for Northern Ireland
- Irish Government can put forward views on non-devolved NI matters

> It will establish a standing British-Irish Intergovernmental Conference, which will subsume both the Anglo-Irish Intergovernmental Council and the Intergovernmental Conference established under the 1985 Agreement.

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Principle of Consent

- Legally recognized Northern Ireland as part of the UK
- "Border Poll" - United Ireland only possible with majority in North and South
- Republic of Ireland removed territorial claim to the North from constitution

> It is hereby declared that Northern Ireland in its entirety remains part of the United Kingdom and shall not cease to be so without the consent of a majority of the people of Northern Ireland.

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Security and Justice Reforms

- decommissioning of paramilitary groups

> All participants accordingly reaffirm their commitment to the total disarmament of all paramilitary organisations.

- police reforms
- prisoner release

> Both Governments will put in place mechanisms to provide for an accelerated programme for the release of prisoners.

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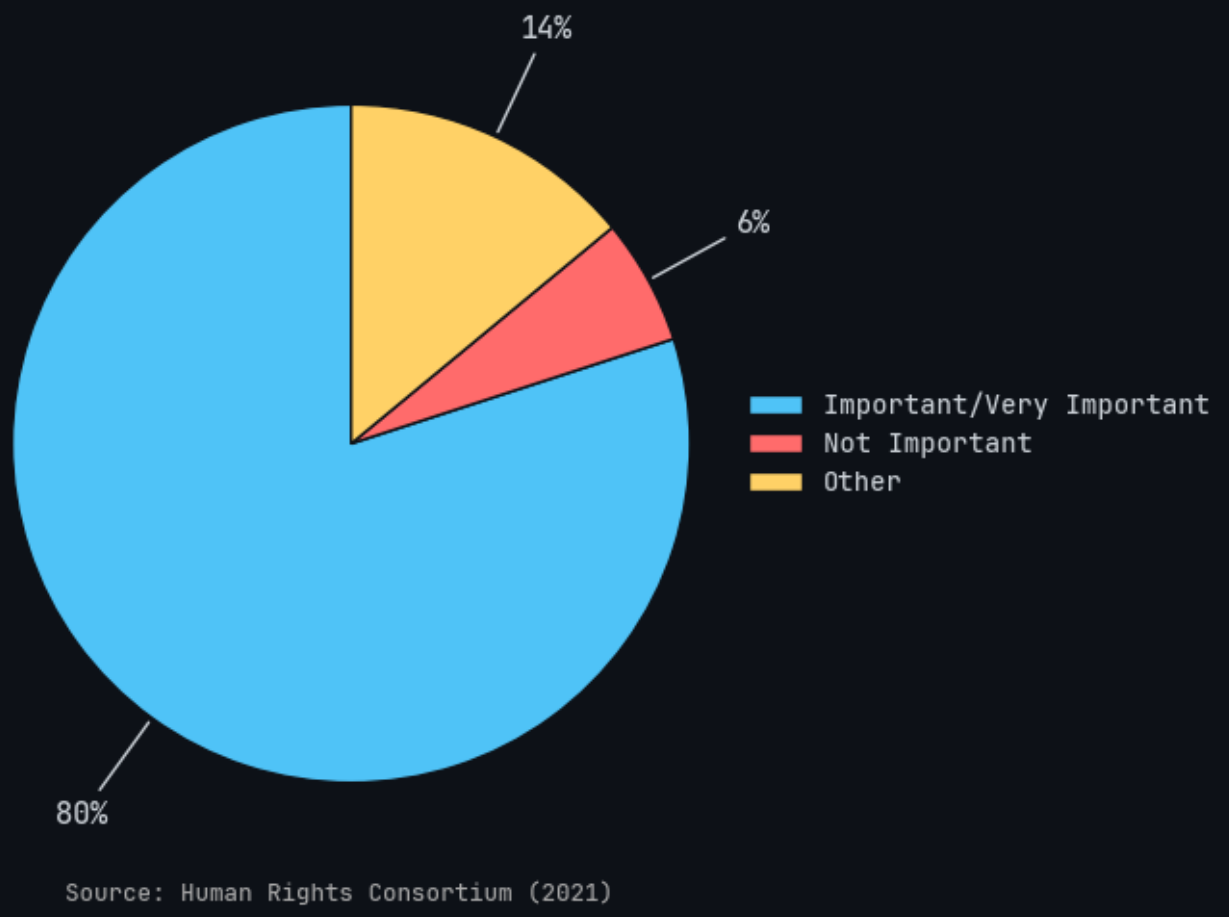
Legal Dimension

- new framework around human rights
- decommissioning
- constitutional guarantees
- links to ECHR (European Convention on Human Rights)

promises have only partly been implemented



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Political and Institutional Dimension

- classic model of power sharing
- negotiated conflict managament

institutions only work if all stakeholders cooperate

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Economical Dimension

- broad agenda for economic resurrection
- peace dividend
- 'disappointingly small' impact for some communities

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Social/Cultural Dimension

- building mutual respect
- police reform
- civic forum

> A consultative Civic Forum will be established.[...]
> It will act as a consultative mechanism on social, economic and cultural issues

→ *too little done to address the issues*

Evaluation

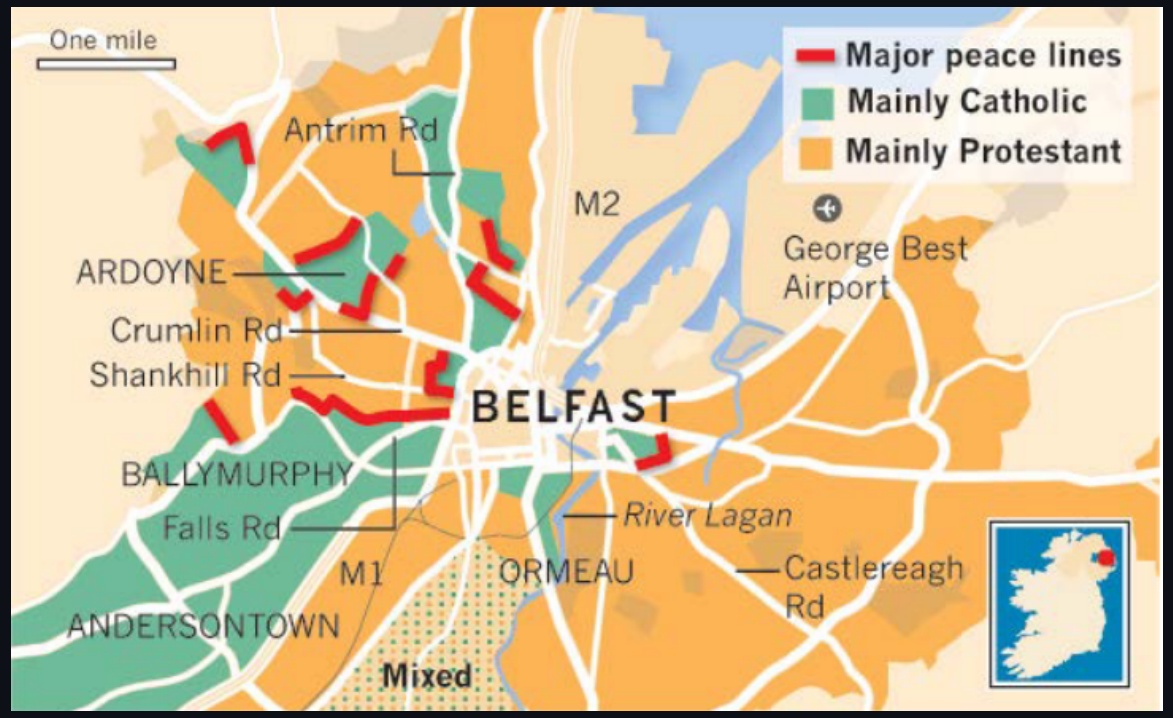
Weaknesses (→ temporary solution)	Strengths (→ sustainable peace)
Divided Society	End of the Violence
Political Stalling	Stable Political System

Evaluation - Weaknesses

Divided Society

- Ongoing Division
  - Schools separated religiously
  - Segregation in electoral behaviour
  - Resedential segregation

Evaluation Criteria: ***Tolerance***



Evaluation - Weaknesses

Political Stalling

- Institutions vulnerable to political deadlocks
  - Vetoes delay decisions

Evaluation Criteria: ***Ability to Act***

Evaluation - Strengths

End of the Violence

- Agreement improved day-to-day live for citizens

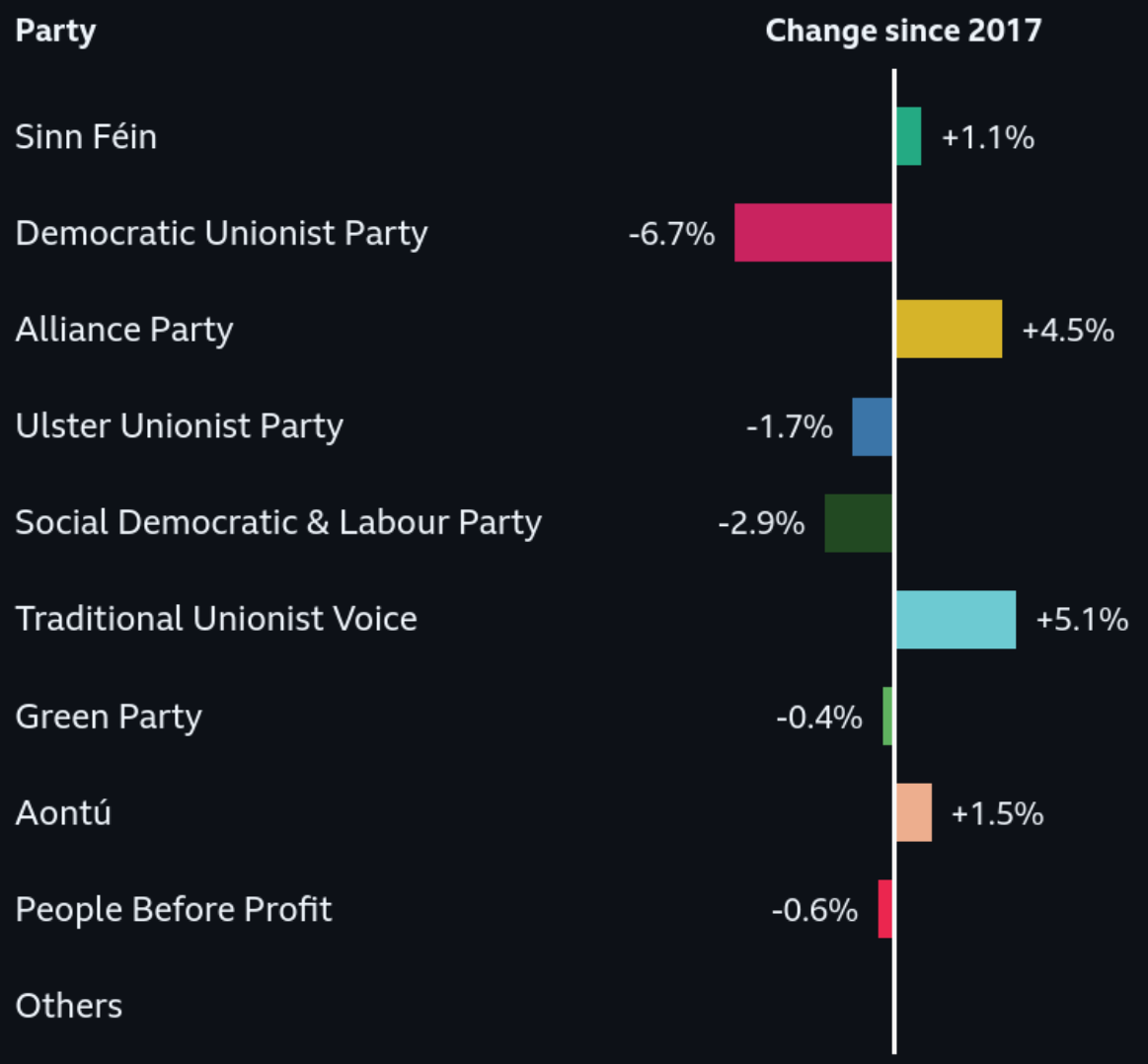
> [...] my teenage years were immeasurably safer and more normal than those of my parents, largely because of the Agreement and the work which led up to it

- Most paramilitary organizations stopped fighting

Evaluation - Strengths

Stable Political System

- Provided a slow, but working system for the past 28 years
- Danger of a broken system prevent system from breaking



Evaluation

Final Verdict

- No definitive answer possible
- Cross community parties on uprise
- Tends to get sustainable at the moment

Evaluation

Possible Improvments

- Legally binding deadlines for Bill of Rights and a permanent Civic Forum
- Removal of peace walls
  → adresses residential segregation
- Development of new social reconciliation strategies
  → preferrably also legally binding

Thank you for your attention!

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